NewsBank inc.

california - Lawmakers double 'Trump-proof' effort to $50 million, including legal aid

January 14, 2025 | Daily Breeze (Torrance, CA)
Author: By Lia Russell and Nicole Nixon The Sacramento Bee | Section: News | 503 Words
Page: 4
OpenURL Link

Democratic lawmakers said Monday that they had reached an agreement advancing a $50 million fund to prepare the state for potential litigation with incoming President Donald Trump, who takes office next week.

Gov. Gavin Newsom called for a special session last month to shore up legal resources and defend against attacks on reproductive health care, climate change policies and immigrant communities, all of which Trump repeatedly criticized on the campaign trail.

Sen. Scott Wiener, a San Francisco Democrat, on Monday announced amended legislation to provide $25 million in funding in grants for local legal aid agencies. That bill will complement one put forth by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel, an Encino Democrat, that calls for the state to provide $25 million in funding for the Department of Justice.

Legislative leaders did not immediately comment on the new legislation but have supported efforts to bolster legal resources ahead of Trump's second term. Senate President pro Tem Mike McGuire told The Bee last week the special session and aiding wildfire victims are "not mutually exclusive."

Wiener drew a direct line between the additional funding and Trump's previous threats to withhold federal disaster relief aid as the death toll from the ongoing Los Angeles wildfires reached 24.

"National MAGA Republicans wasted no time politicizing the horrific tragedy unfolding in Los Angeles. As the fires burned, the President-elect, his allies, and senior Congressional Republican officials proposed withholding California's disaster aid and imposing unprecedented conditions on this humanitarian relief," Wiener said. "These inhumane threats show yet again why California must be prepared to counter the cruel and prejudicial attacks the incoming administration is preparing to launch against California."

So far, Trump has not threatened to cut off money for wildfire victims, who are eligible to apply for federal relief after President Joe Biden signed off on Newsom's request to declare a federal disaster last week.

But Trump has repeatedly threatened to block California's federal funding if Newsom doesn't capitulate to his demands to divert water to farmers. House Speaker Mike Johnson, a Louisiana Republican, told reporters Monday that he personally believed "there should be conditions" on disaster relief aid for California.

Trump falsely accused Newsom of hampering officials' response to the fire by not signing a so-called "water restoration declaration" that he said would allow for water to "flow" from the northern part of the state into Southern California.

Newsom's office called this "pure fiction." His office did not immediately respond to a request for comment about the new legislation. Newsom remained in the Los Angeles area Monday to oversee the emergency response.

Legislative Republicans criticized Newsom for calling a special session to "Trump-proof" the state, and said he should convene a session to focus on wildfire response and the ongoing home insurance crisis.

In a statement, Assembly Minority Leader James Gallagher said Democratic lawmakers were prioritizing creating a "slush fund" for "hypothetical fights against the federal government" when they should be "laser-focused on responding to the devastating wildfires in L.A."

The governor invited Trump in a letter sent Friday to see the wildfire destruction firsthand. Trump did not immediately respond.

Copyright (c) 2025, Daily Breeze, All Rights Reserved

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Lia Russell and Nicole Nixon, B. (2025, January 14). california Lawmakers double 'Trump-proof' effort to $50 million, including legal aid. *Daily Breeze (Torrance, CA)*, p. 4. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19E18C9C5E458300.